Methodological quality, guidance, and tools in scoping reviews: a scoping review protocol

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ABSTRACT

Objective: The objective of this scoping review is to identify and report on evidence (such as guidance) or tools regarding methodological quality or risk of bias of scoping reviews.

Introduction: Scoping reviews have gained popularity in recent years but have been criticized for variations in their approaches. This scoping review will examine evidence on the methodological quality of scoping reviews. It will also identify and describe potential methods to inform the development of a tool for appraising the methodological quality of scoping reviews.

Inclusion criteria: This review will consider all documents reporting on the development, evaluation, or use of tools addressing the critical appraisal or risk of bias of scoping reviews. The search will seek evidence published from 2005 onwards, corresponding with the publication of Arksey and O'Malley's framework for scoping reviews.

Methods: A three-step search strategy will be used to locate both published and unpublished documents. An initial search of MEDLINE identified keywords and MeSH terms. A second search of MEDLINE, Embase, and CINAHL will follow. Google and Google Scholar will be searched for difficult-to-locate and unpublished literature. The authors will use their professional networks, social media accounts, and professional newsletters to contact methodologists to obtain any additional materials. Documents will be independently screened, selected, and extracted by two researchers, and the data will be presented in tables.

Keywords: critical appraisal; evidence syntheses; methodology; risk of bias; scoping review

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Introduction

Scoping reviews have become a popular form of evidence synthesis[1,2] and can be conducted for a variety of reasons. They may be used to identify the types of available evidence, or key characteristics and factors related to a particular concept. They may also be used to identify knowledge gaps or to describe the methodological approaches used in a certain topic or field.[2,3] Scoping reviews can also precede the conduct of a systematic review. Methodologically' scoping reviews differ substantially from systematic reviews. Scoping reviews have a broader research question that is hypothesis-generating, while systematic reviews have a narrower focus that can be hypothesis-testing and typically assesses the feasibility, appropriateness, meaningfulness, and/or effectiveness of an issue.[2,4] Scoping reviews are also used to examine the knowledge on a topic for the

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All authors included in this protocol are members of the JBI Scoping Review Methodology group and have published the JBI guidance for scoping reviews. ACT is a member of the JBI Evidence Synthesis *Editorial Advisory Board. DP and ZM are paid members of JBI, Adelaide.*

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purpose of concept clarification. A key difference between scoping and systematic reviews is that systematic reviews must include critical appraisal or risk of bias assessment. In contrast, it is not mandatory for scoping reviews to assess the quality of included evidence. Instead, they provide an overview or map of the available evidence rather than synthesized findings for implementation into policy or practice.[2,5]

While critical appraisal of the sources of evidence included in scoping reviews is generally omitted, the reviews themselves may still need to be assessed for bias if they are to be used for decision-making or to inform future research directions.[6] There is a difference between assessing bias and assessing methodological quality in systematic reviews. Risk of bias assesses whether the included studies should be believed, while methodological quality assesses certain features dependent on study design, such as whether blinding occurred in a randomized controlled trial.[6] Simply assessing methodological quality has been criticized because a study may have good methodological quality yet still be at risk of bias. Studies that contain potential bias call into question the trustworthiness, value, and relevance of the included information and the studies' internal and (sometimes) external validity. Critical appraisal and risk of bias assessments, therefore, help to interpret and determine the reliability and validity of the included studies and subsequent findings.[6]

There are a variety of tools that critically appraise and determine the risk of bias for original research and systematic reviews.[7-9] Risk of bias and methodological quality tools for systematic reviews include AMSTAR (a measurement tool to assess systematic reviews)[10] and AMSTAR 2,[11] CASP (Critical Appraisal Skills Programme),[12] ROBIS (Risk Of Bias in Systematic Reviews),[13] and the JBI critical appraisal checklist for systematic reviews and research syntheses.[14] Other tools are more specific to the type of evidence synthesis design; for example, individual participant data reviews[15] or meta-analysis.[16]

The conduct of scoping reviews has repeatedly been found to be inconsistent — that is, there is no one standard approach followed by all authors, which may increase potential bias.[1,17] Despite not providing synthesized findings in the same manner as systematic reviews, scoping reviews can identify potential implications for future research directions. Therefore, the findings from scoping reviews can be used to inform decision-making for the development of policy or guidelines. Based on the current use of scoping review findings, stakeholders still need the validity and reliability of scoping reviews. Our preliminary search identified two checklists that address reporting standards in scoping reviews.[18,19] However, it is currently unknown whether there are further tools that critically appraise or determine risk of bias in scoping reviews that have been developed using internationally established standards.

A preliminary search of PubMed, Open Science Framework, the Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews, and *JBI Evidence Synthesis* was conducted. There have been recent reviews to summarize the tools used for original research,[20-22] guidelines,[23] and systematic reviews.[7] Zeng *et al.*[24] conducted a comprehensive systematic review on critical appraisal and risk of bias tools, checklists, and guidance for preclinical and clinical studies, systematic reviews and meta-analyses, and clinical practice guidelines; however, scoping reviews were not considered. There are no current or in-progress systematic reviews or scoping reviews that have assessed tools to appraise the quality and bias in scoping reviews. Therefore, the objective of this scoping review is to identify and report on evidence, such as guidance, or tools to assess methodological quality or risk of bias in scoping reviews.

Review question

What are the existing tools or guidance that discusses the validity, methodological quality, reporting, or risk of bias for scoping reviews?

- What domains are included in the risk of bias tools or reporting guidance?
- What type of bias do the risk of bias tools assess?
- What process and psychometric assessments were undertaken to determine the validity and reliability of the risk of bias tools?
- What items (questions or criteria) are included in the tools?

Inclusion criteria

Concept

This review will consider documents that discuss the methodological quality, risk of bias, reporting quality, or critical appraisal of scoping reviews. This may be in the form of frameworks, guidance, commentaries, tools, or reporting checklists. This scoping review will also include evidence that describes the

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development, application, and evaluation (validity and reliability) of risk of bias or critical appraisal tools that assess reliability and bias in scoping reviews. The terms ''risk of bias,'' ''methodological quality,'' and ''critical appraisal'' may be used interchangeably within the literature. Therefore, evidence sources that include any of these terms or address similar concepts will be included.

Context

The tools/guidance may be conducted in any field and not limited to medicine or health. We will include guidance from any jurisdiction developed by any group globally.

Types of sources

This scoping review will consider published and non-peer-reviewed evidence. These sources will consider quantitative, qualitative, and mixed methods designs, irrespective of methodological approach. Commentaries, editorials, frameworks, guidance documents, and conference abstracts will also be considered for inclusion.

Methods

The conduct of this protocol was guided by the JBI methodology for scoping reviews[3] and reported using the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis Protocols (PRISMA-P).[25] This is because guidance for scoping review protocols does not yet exist. The proposed scoping review will be conducted in accordance with the JBI methodology for scoping reviews.[3,26] In reporting the scoping review, the PRISMA extension for Scoping Reviews (PRISMA-ScR) will be utilized.[18]

Search strategy

The search strategy and the initial and secondary searches were conducted in collaboration with a research librarian. The search strategy will aim to locate both published and unpublished studies. An initial limited search of MEDLINE (PubMed) was undertaken to identify articles on the topic. The text words contained in the titles and abstracts of relevant articles and the MeSH terms describing the articles were used to develop a full search strategy (see Appendix I). The search strategy, including all identified keywords and index terms, will be adapted for each included database and/or information source. MEDLINE (Ovid), CINAHL (EBSCO), and Embase (Ovid) will be searched. Google Scholar and Google will be searched in incognito mode to remove the influence of past search histories on the result. The following keywords will be used: ''scoping reviews'' AND tools OR instruments OR guidance ''critical appraisal'' OR quality OR ''risk of bias.'' Following the advice of Haddaway *et al.*,[27] the first 200 results will be screened for suitability. The following websites will also be screened to identify relevant unpublished sources:

- EQUATOR Network (https://www.equator-network.org/);
- Centre for Evidence-Based Medicine (https://www.cebm.net/);
- Centre for Reviews and Dissemination (https://www.york.ac.uk/crd/);
- Critical Appraisal Skills Programme (https://casp-uk.net/);
- McMaster's Centre for Evidence-Based Medicine (https://hslmcmaster.libguides.com/c.php?g=306765&p=2044668);
- Evidence Synthesis International (https://evidencesynthesis.org/);
- JBI (https://JBI.global/);
- Campbell Collaboration (https://campbellcollaboration.org/).

The reference lists of all included sources of evidence will be screened for additional documents. The research team (who are all members of the JBI Scoping Review Methodology Group) will also submit evidence sources to be considered for inclusion. The authors will request resources from stakeholders, such as researchers who specialize in evidence-based health care, evidence synthesis methodology, or scoping reviews, for inclusion in this scoping review. This consultation process will be initiated via an advertisement placed in three methodology newsletters: the JBI Scoping Review Network, Strategy for Patient Oriented Research Evidence Alliance, and the Knowledge Translation Canada e-newsletter. A social media callout will also occur via the authors' social media accounts (Twitter and LinkedIn) to gather as much evidence as possible. A tweet or post will be sent out describing the scoping review and asking whether there are any resources that should be included. This tweet or post will then be re-tweeted or shared to increase the probability of finding more resources.

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Studies published in any language will be included. Any potential sources that are in a language other than English will be initially translated through Google translate, and, if deemed to meet the inclusion criteria, the full text will be professionally translated. The literature search will be restricted to 2005 to the present, as that is when the seminal work of Arksey and O'Malley was published.[28]

Study selection

Following the search, all identified citations will be collated into Endnote v.X9 (Clarivate Analytics, PA, USA) and duplicates removed. An initial pilot test of 10 evidence sources will be conducted to ensure clarity and consistency in the application of the inclusion and exclusion criteria during the title and abstract screening. Following the pilot test, two independent reviews will screen titles and abstracts against the inclusion criteria for the review using the JBI System for the Unified Management, Assessment and Review of Information (JBI SUMARI; JBI, Adelaide, Australia).[29] Potentially relevant sources will be retrieved in full. Following a similar process to the pilot test, at least two independent reviewers will assess the full text of selected citations in detail against the inclusion criteria. Reasons for exclusion of full-text articles that do not meet the inclusion criteria will be recorded and reported in a supplementary document in the scoping review. Any disagreements that arise between the reviewers at each stage of the selection process will be resolved through discussion or with an additional reviewer. The results of the search and the study inclusion process will be reported in full in the final scoping review and presented in a PRISMA flow diagram.[30]

Data extraction

The data extraction form will be pilot tested on three evidence sources to assess reliability and consistency of the extraction, as well as the appropriateness and usability of the form (see Appendix II). Following pilot testing, two reviewers will independently extract data from papers included in the scoping review using a finalized data extraction form. Extraction in scoping reviews is typically an iterative process; therefore, it is expected that the draft extraction form will be further refined during the initial extraction pilot. Weekly meetings between the data extractors will occur during this stage to ensure that the data extraction form continues to be appropriate for the evidence being extracted, and to assess whether any potential changes need to be made. Thus, the data extraction form will be modified and revised as necessary during the process of extracting data from each evidence source. The successive iterations of the data extraction form will be recorded in the scoping review.

It is expected that the data extracted will include study characteristics, such as the aim, location, methods, design/type as well as participant characteristics, findings, and any conflicts of interest declared by the authors. The articles that describe the development of a critical appraisal or risk of bias tool will also have data extracted related to tool characteristics and the items included. Extractions will include the following:

- name of the tool;
- the stakeholder audience that the tool is intended for; whether the tool is intended for a particular field (eg, health care, engineering); the items or components of the tool;
- how the items of the tool were presented (ie, statements, questions, or prompts); types of bias being assessed;
- the individual items or domains themselves;
- bias being assessed;
- process followed to develop the tool;
- methodology used to develop the tool;
- validity and reliability properties that were reported.

Any disagreements that arise between the reviewers will be resolved through discussion or with an additional reviewer. If appropriate, authors of papers will be contacted to request missing or additional data.

Data analysis and presentation

Extracted data will be presented in tables, with further visual formats to be considered at the time of analysis. It is anticipated that the evidence will initially be categorized into the following:

- general discussion of the methodological quality of scoping reviews;
- evidence that discussed reporting guidance;
- evidence that focused on critical appraisal and risk of bias in scoping reviews;
- where a tool was developed, or whether its validity and reliability were tested.

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There will be further categorization of those documents where a tool was developed. This will involve the median and interquartile range of items to be calculated across all tools as well as tabulating the frequency of different biases identified in the tools.

A table of the available tools for scoping reviews will be developed. A preliminary list of risk of bias items will be gathered, and then similar items will be grouped together. An agreement on further analysis and presentation will occur amongst the research team after data extraction.

Dissemination of the process and results of the scoping review and potential future development of scoping review risk of bias tools will occur through JBI, the Scoping Review Network Newsletter, the JBI Scoping Review Website, YouTube, and social media (Twitter and Facebook). This will be done through a research brief, which will be posted on the Knowledge Translation Canada website, and the authors' respective researchgate.com pages. Future research will involve a modified Delphi method to vote on the items identified within the scoping review.

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Appendix I: Search strategy

MEDLINE (PubMed)

An initial search was conducted on the May 20, 2020, with the filter from >2005, with the following search strategy:

((Tools [Title/Abstract] or instruments [Title/Abstract] or guidance [Title/Abstract] or 'guideline adherence' [MeSH Terms] Or checklist [Title/Abstract] or Checklist [MeSH terms] or scale [Title/Abstract] or item [Title/Abstract]) AND ('risk of bias'[Title/Abstract] OR bias[Title/Abstract] OR 'critical appraisal'[Title/Abstract] OR critical assessment'[Title/Abstract] OR 'critical evaluation'[Title/Abstract] OR critical review'[Title/Abstract] OR 'quality appraisal'[Title/Abstract] OR 'quality assessment'[Title/Abstract] OR 'quality evaluation'[Title/Abstract] OR 'quality review'[Title/Abstract] OR 'research appraisal'[Title/Abstract] OR research assessment'[Title/Abstract] OR 'research evaluation'[Title/Abstract] OR 'research review'[Title/Abstract] OR 'methodological guidance'[Title/Abstract] OR 'methodological standards'[Title/ Abstract] OR 'methodological quality'[Title/Abstract] OR 'reporting guidance'[Title/Abstract] OR 'reporting standards'[Title/Abstract]) OR validity [Title/Abstract]) AND scoping [Title/Abstract] OR 'Review literature as Topic' [MeSH Major Topic])

((((((''Tools''[Title/Abstract] OR ''instruments''[Title/Abstract] OR ''guidance''[Title/Abstract] OR ''guideline adherence''[MeSH Terms]) AND (''Or''[All Fields] AND ''checklist''[Title/Abstract])) OR ''checklist''[MeSH Terms] OR ''scale''[Title/Abstract] OR ''item''[Title/Abstract]) AND (''risk of bias''[Title/Abstract] OR ''bias''[Title/Abstract] OR ''critical appraisal''[Title/Abstract] OR ''critical assessment''[Title/Abstract] OR ''critical evaluation''[Title/Abstract] OR ''critical review''[Title/Abstract] OR ''quality appraisal''[Title/Abstract] OR ''quality assessment''[Title/Abstract] OR ''quality evaluation''[Title/Abstract] OR ''quality review''[Title/Abstract] OR ''research appraisal''[Title/Abstract] OR ''research assessment''[Title/Abstract] OR ''research evaluation''[Title/Abstract] OR ''research review''[Title/Abstract] OR ''methodological guidance''[Title/Abstract] OR ''methodological standards''[Title/Abstract] OR ''methodological quality''[Title/Abstract] OR ''reporting guidance''[Title/Abstract] OR ''reporting standards''[Title/Abstract])) OR ''validity''[Title/Abstract]) AND ''scoping''[Title/Abstract]) OR ''review literature as topic''[MeSH Major Topic]

A total of 5105 results were found.

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Appendix II: Data extraction instrument

Name of tool	Field and stakeholder audience	How the items of the tool were presented (ie, statements, questions, or prompts)	Items included in the tool	Bias being assessed	Process followed for development of the tool	Methods used in tool development	Validity and reliability properties

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